

MIDNIGHT NOODLES

a screenplay segment

INT. LATE-NIGHT DINER – NIGHT

A narrow room with cracked vinyl booths, a flickering "OPEN" sign bleeding red onto rain-streaked windows. A clock above the counter reads 2:47. The only other sound: a fan whining overhead, pushing warm air through smoke.

Two men sit across from each other in the corner booth. TANG (40s, gaunt, fresh creases on a cheap shirt, eyes that have slept on concrete) and LO (40s, cleaner hands, a jacket that fits a little too well, the kind of stillness that comes from carrying a badge).

Between them: two bowls of beef noodle soup, steam rising slow.

TANG lifts his chopsticks. Taps the rim of his bowl – once, twice – a small metallic ring that hangs in the air.

TANG

Still heavy on the salt here.

LO

(stirring, not looking up)

Lao Chen never could measure.
Twenty years, same hand, same spoon.

TANG

Some things you can't
un-season.

A beat. TANG picks a slice of beef from the broth, studies it like evidence, sets it back.

LO

You eat it anyway.

TANG

What else is there to eat at
this hour.

LO lights a cigarette. The match flares, then dies. Smoke crawls up past his eyes. He doesn't inhale right

away – holds it, watches the ember.

LO

The soup's been boiling since
six. You came in at two.

TANG

I came in when I came in.

LO

(taps ash into a chipped
saucer)

A man's gotta know when to walk
in. And when to walk out.

TANG's chopsticks hover. He smiles – barely.

TANG

You always were the one who
liked the door.

The fan clicks. Outside, a car passes, headlights
sliding across LO's face, catching the collar of his
jacket, the shape beneath it.

TANG

(quiet)

You still carry that weight
around?

LO

Habit.

TANG

Heavy habit.

LO

Lighter than most.

TANG blows on a spoonful of broth. Drinks it slow. Sets
the spoon down with deliberate care.

TANG

Lao Chen used to leave the back
door open. Remember? We'd come
in through the alley, eat, slip
out before the second bowl got
cold.

LO

He stopped doing that.

TANG

When?

LO

Around the time the alley got
bright. New lights. New faces
asking questions.

TANG

(soft)

Ah.

He picks up the small dish of chili oil. Tilts it,
watching the red slide toward the rim but never
spilling.

TANG

You ever miss the dark, Lo?

LO

I miss the food. I don't miss
the dark.

TANG

Funny. The dark misses you.

LO's cigarette burns down a full centimeter untouched.
He finally pulls on it, exhales a long stream toward the
ceiling fan. The fan chops the smoke into ribbons.

LO

I'm not the one who left, Tang.

TANG

No. You're the one who stayed.
Stayed so still the whole
street forgot you were sitting
there.

A long silence. TANG lifts noodles, lets them drip. The
strands fall back into the bowl like rope.

TANG

They say a man who sits that
still is either asleep – or
hunting.

LO

Or guarding something.

TANG

Or that.

Their eyes meet. First time in the scene. Hold.

LO

You finished?

TANG

(looking at his bowl,
half-full)

Not yet.

LO

It'll get cold.

TANG

I've eaten colder.

LO nods, slow. He reaches into his jacket. TANG doesn't move – only his fingers tighten on the chopsticks, knuckles going pale.

But LO pulls out only a folded paper. Slides it across the table between the bowls.

LO

Bus terminal. North line.
Six-fifteen. Window seat's
empty if you want it.

TANG

(doesn't touch it)
And if I don't want it?

LO

Then the noodles get cold, and
you finish them anyway, and you
walk out that door at three –
and nobody walks out that door
at three.

TANG stares at the paper. The fan whines. A drop of condensation slides down his water glass like a slow tear.

TANG

You'd let me walk?

LO

I'd let you ride.

TANG

And him?

LO's jaw tightens. He grinds the cigarette out in the saucer. A small hiss.

LO

Him I can't season for you.

TANG

No.

LO

That broth's already been poured.

TANG finally picks up the paper. Folds it once, slides it into his shirt pocket, over his heart. He picks up his chopsticks, eats – really eats – three quick mouthfuls of noodle, fast, like a man who hasn't tasted anything in years.

TANG

(chewing)

The salt.

LO

Yeah.

TANG

You get used to it.

LO

You do.

TANG drains the last of his broth. Sets the bowl down with a soft clink. He stands. LO stays seated.

TANG

The back door.

LO

(reaching under the counter, he flips a key onto the table)

Still sticks. Lift and push.

TANG

Lift and push.

He walks toward the rear. Pauses. Doesn't turn.

TANG

The food here was never the point.

LO

I know.

TANG

But I'll miss it.

LO

So will I.

TANG lifts the latch. Pushes. The door groans open, letting in a slice of cold rain and the sound of a distant truck. He steps out. The door swings shut behind him with a soft click.

LO sits alone. He picks up TANG's bowl, drags it toward himself. Looks down at the leftover broth – the thin film of oil, the single slice of beef TANG left behind.

He picks up the chopsticks. Eats it.

Then he reaches for his phone. Holds it a long moment. Sets it back down, face-down on the table.

The clock ticks to 2:53.

The fan keeps turning.

FADE OUT.